“One hundred and eighty francs.”

“So we need thirty francs. I’m sure the pastels—”

“And then what do we do for November? And afterwards? She’s so greedy that in another few months, she’ll raise the rent again.” Léa pointed at the paper. “Women are making good salaries working in German arms factories. They can afford to pay these prices.” She shook her head. “But we can’t.”

Rose pressed her lips together as if she didn’t know what to say or do. There was a solution Léa had considered before, but feared it was the first step in a downward spiral that the sisters couldn’t escape.

“We could move to a cheaper boardinghouse. Find a room for seventy to ninety francs a month without meals—”

“But we’re already skipping lunch. Will we have to drop dinner?”

“We’ll manage.” Léa had no idea how.

“I hate this war. All it does is destroy.” She went silent for a moment. “It’s not fair. We should be in love, raising children, and happy. We can’t let this war destroy us, too.”

“We won’t.” Léa feared it would but she didn’t want to tell Rose that. “We don’t need to have all the answers now. Something will fall into our lap. Everything will work out. Tomorrow, I’ll go around to the boardinghouses to see if we can find a cheaper one. Now, tell me about André. You were saying that he’s invited you somewhere.”

Rose smiled. “*Us*. He’s invited us to come to the vineyard on Saturday, where he works. He wants to meet you.”

“Me?”

“I told him all about you. And I think they need extra hands to help with the *vendange*. I’m so excited to spend a whole day with him. Please come?”

Despite herself, Léa nodded. “Of course. I want to meet him, too.” She forced a tight smile. It would be an opportunity to find out more about André and what he might be involved in. Rose was too young and inexperienced to realize the dangers circling them. “And maybe getting out of Orléans for a day is just what we need to figure out what we do next.”

* * *

On Saturday morning, there was a chill in the air, but the sun was out and